



**THIS IS WHY I
MISSED YOUR
LECTURE**



ABSENCE HAPPENS QUIETLY...

OVER THE DURATION OF A 3-YEAR COURSE THOSE WHO HAVE BEEN DIAGNOSED WITH MENSTRUATION RELATED ILLNESS MISS AROUND 11 WEEKS OF CLASSES (FOX, 2025). FOR MANY WOMEN, MISSING OUT ON THEIR EDUCATION DUE TO PERIODS, IS NOT RARE OR OCCASIONAL, IT IS EVERY MONTH. IF PERIODS AND THEIR DIFFICULTIES ARE OFTEN PREDICTABLE, WHY ARE THEY NOT TAKEN INTO CONSIDERATION IN THE EDUCATION SYSTEM. MENSTRUATION FREQUENTLY MEANS MISSING 1-3 DAYS A MONTH OF LESSONS (CHIMA, 2023). THIS CAN RESULT IN STUDENTS FALLING BEHIND AND WORKING TWICE AS HARD TO CATCH UP. THIS CAN BE SPECIFICALLY DEVASTATING FOR THOSE WITH CONDITIONS SUCH AS ENDOMETRIOSIS, POLYCYSTIC OVARY SYNDROME AND SEVERE IRREGULAR PERIODS, AS THEY TEND TO NEED MORE ABSENCE AND ARE BATTLING WITH CHRONIC PAIN THROUGHOUT THE MONTH. ALTHOUGH THIS AFFECTS HALF THE POPULATION IT IS TREATED AS A PERSONAL ISSUE RATHER THAN AN ISSUE THAT INSTITUTIONS SHOULD CONSIDER.

"I DO FEEL LIKE I HAVE TO MISS SOME SEMINARS DUE TO BAD PERIOD PAINS THAT I GET, AND WHEN I START MY MENSTRUAL CYCLE IT MAKES ME TIRED AND GROGGY SO I STRUGGLE TO GET MY WORK DONE IN MY OWN TIME."

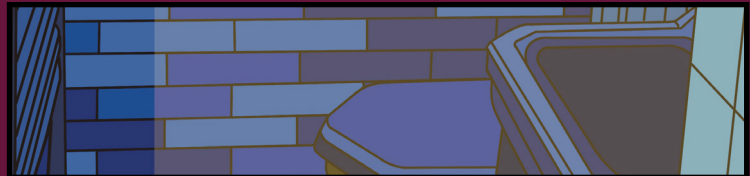




JUST BECAUSE YOU CAN'T SEE IT...

FOR MANY WOMEN PERIODS ARE NOT JUST A MILD DISCOMFORT, THEY ARE DEBILITATING. SYMPTOMS GO FAR BEYOND STOMACH CRAMPS. SYMPTOMS INCLUDE: INTENSE STOMACH CRAMPS THAT CAN SPREAD TO THE BACK AND THIGHS, HEADACHES, DIZZINESS, NAUSEA, DIARRHOEA, FATIGUE, BLOATING, EXTREME MOOD SWINGS AND HEAVY BLEEDING. COMMONLY, THESE SYMPTOMS ARE EXPERIENCED IN COMBINATION AND OFTEN OVER-THE-COUNTER PAINKILLERS DON'T MAKE A DIFFERENCE. ALTHOUGH THESE SYMPTOMS PEAK WHEN MENSTRUATION BEGINS, SYMPTOMS OFTEN BEGIN 1 WEEK PRIOR AND CONTINUE TO 1 WEEK AFTER MENSTRUATION. FOR THOSE WITH CONDITIONS SUCH AS PREMENSTRUAL DYSPHORIC DISORDER (PMDD) SYMPTOMS ARE MUCH MORE INTENSE, EXTREME ANXIETY AND DEPRESSIVE EPISODES CAN BEGIN UP TO 2 WEEKS BEFORE MENSTRUATION BEGINS (OASH | OFFICE ON WOMEN'S HEALTH, 2021). THIS LEVEL OF MENTAL AND PHYSICAL DISCOMFORT IS OFTEN NOT RECOGNISED IN EDUCATION AND REMAINS OVERLOOKED. IT SEEMS THAT PUSHING THROUGH WHEN PAIN IS UNBEARABLE IS ENCOURAGED, IN THE NAME OF GOOD ATTENDANCE. IF SUPPORT IS GIVEN IT IS OFTEN ONLY AVAILABLE TO THOSE WITH A DIAGNOSIS, THIS IS A BIG ISSUE AS IN THE UK AS IT CAN TAKE YEARS TO GET A DIAGNOSIS (ON AVERAGE 9 YEARS) FOR MENSTRUAL RELATED ISSUES LIKE ENDOMETRIOSIS (ENDOMETRIOSIS UK, 2024). HELP AND FLEXIBILITY FOR STUDENTS SHOULD BE THE STANDARD.

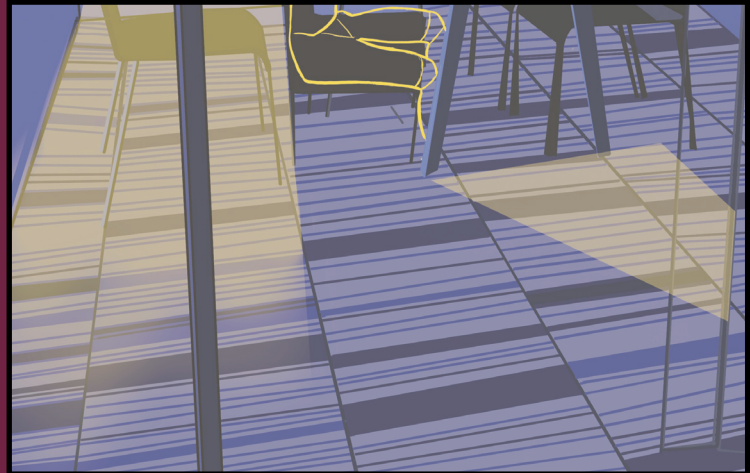
"I HAVE AWFUL MENSTRUAL CYCLES FROM EXTREME CRAMPS TO NAUSEA AND DIZZINESS. UNFORTUNATELY EVERY TIME I GO TO THE GP I AM DISMISSED, CALLED DRAMATIC AND SENT HOME WITH A BIRTH CONTROL SUBSCRIPTION THAT DOES NOTHING."



SHE SHOWS UP ANYWAY

WITH THE WAY THE SYSTEM IS SET UP 'PUSHING THROUGH' THE PAIN CAN SEEM LIKE A REQUIREMENT RATHER THAN A DECISION, MANY FORCE THEMSELVES INTO LECTURES AND WORK AS THEY FEEL THEY HAVE NO ALTERNATIVE. THE LABOUR AND MENTAL LOAD IT TAKES TO MANAGE SYMPTOMS IS INVISIBLE, YET TAKES SUCH A TOLL WITH DEADLINES, LECTURES, AND AN INCREASING WORKLOAD, STRESS, BURNOUT AND ISOLATION BECOMES INEVITABLE. NEGLECTING ONE'S HEALTH IN FAVOUR OF STUDIES INEVITABLY LEADS TO WORSENING SYMPTOMS AND FALLING BEHIND. YET SHOWING UP HAS BECOME MORE IMPORTANT THAN BEING WELL. AT UNIVERSITY THERE IS AN EMPHASIS ON INDEPENDENCE BUT AT SOME POINT INDEPENDENCE REPLACES SUPPORT AND THE EXPECTATION OF MANAGING HEALTH AND STUDIES BECOMES TOO MUCH WITHOUT PROPER SUPPORT SYSTEMS IN PLACE.

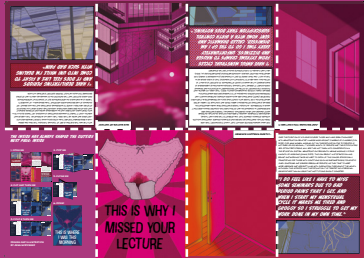
***"I HAVE DEBILITATING PERIODS
AND IT DOES FEEL LIKE A FIGHT TO
COME INTO UNI WHILE I'M DEALING
WITH SUCH BAD PAIN"***



THE INSIDE HAS ALWAYS SHAPED THE OUTSIDE

NEXT PAGE: INSIDE

1. OPEN ME



2. FLIP AND TURN ME



3. FOLD & TURN ME



DESIGN AND ILLUSTRATION
BY JESS SCRIVENER

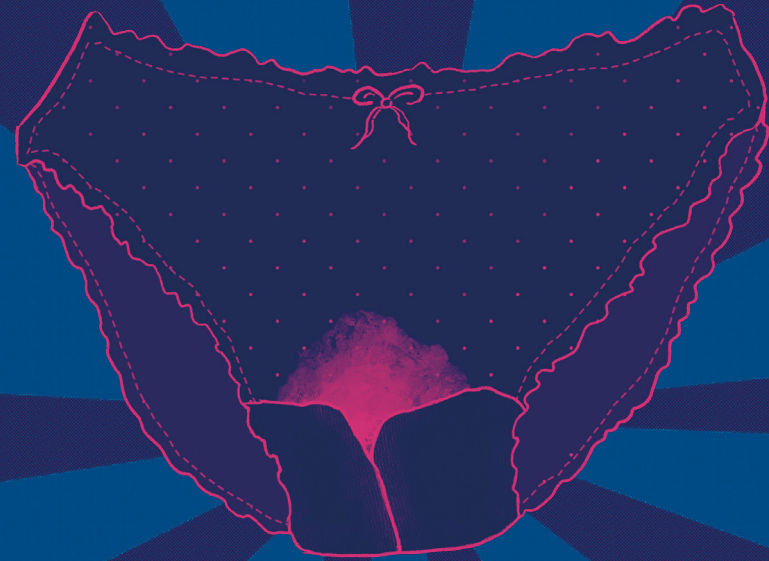
4. POP ME



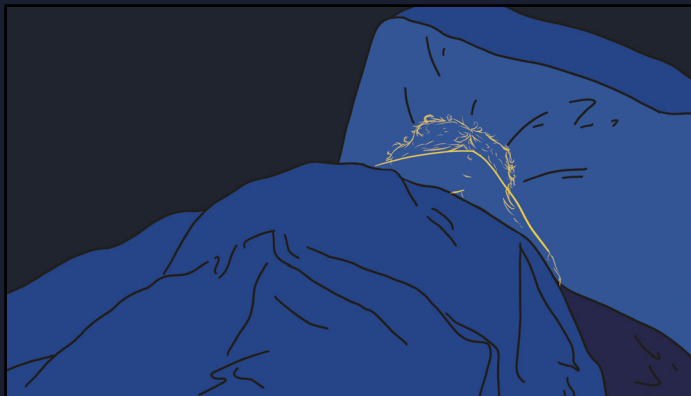
5. CLOSE ME



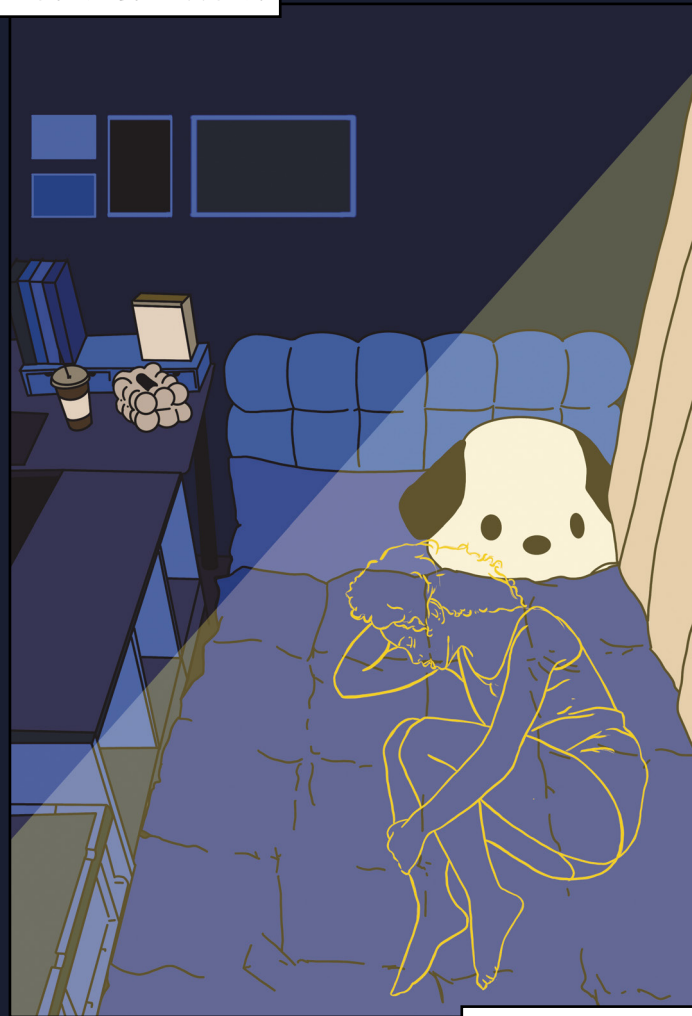
6. DONE!



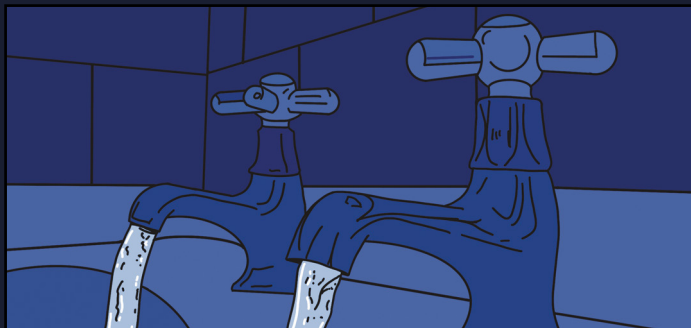
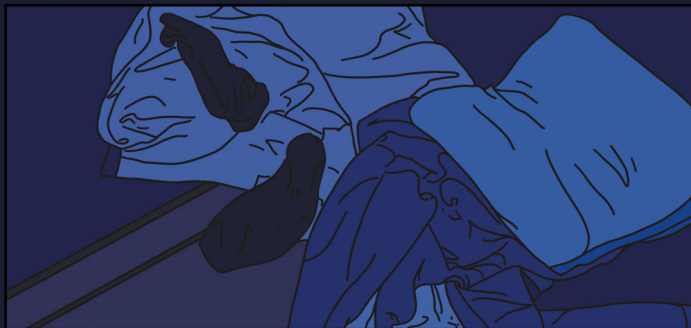
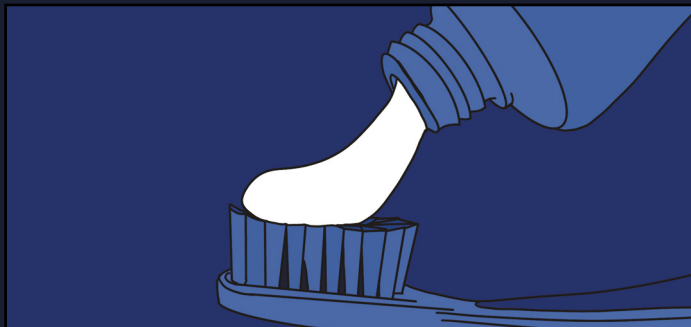
THIS IS WHERE I WAS THIS MORNING



SOME DAYS I DISAPPEAR.



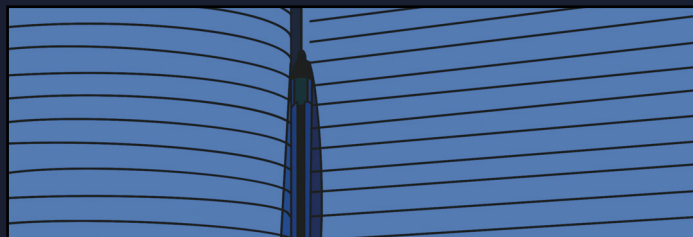
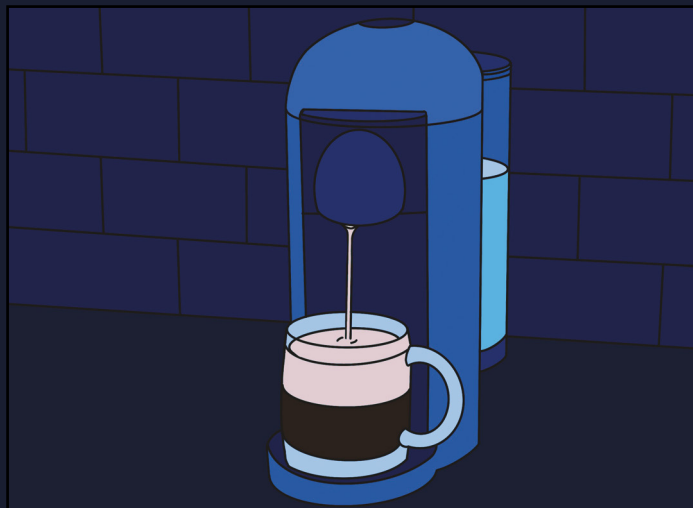
BUT I DONT WANT TO ...



THIS PAIN IS PRIVATE.



I CARRY THIS ALONE.



I CAME DESPITE IT.



I AM HERE IN PAIN.



'I am, we are ... different by design' is an annual student-led zine published by the Department of Typography & Graphic Communication at the University of Reading. This year, the zine was curated, collated and designed by Eleanor Denton, Aurelien Flatman, Grace Johnson, and Jess Scrivener.

This year's edition focuses on four themes: mental health, menstrual health, community & inclusion, and student finances. These were the most commonly raised issues that students in the School of Arts and Communication Design highlighted to us in a survey.

In the University's 100th year, we have brought together and presented under-represented student voices from across the School.

Design and illustration
By Jess Scrivener

Reference list

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- Fox, A. (2025). Impact of Periods Leading Some University Students to Miss Six Weeks of Degree. [online] The Independent. Available at: independent.co.uk/news/uk/home-news/higher-education-policy-institute-hepi-universities-universities-uk-department-for-education-b2792600.html.
- OASH | Office on Women's Health. (2021). Premenstrual Dysphoric Disorder (PMDD) | Office on Women's Health. [online] Available at: womenshealth.gov/menstrual-cycle/premenstrual-syndrome/premenstrual-dysphoric-disorder-pmdd.